for these natural products to be exploited commercially. This region has some of the world's untouched rain forests, thus earning for itself the status of a biodiversity hotspot. Handicrafts of the area are a novelty. The people are handsome, sincere, content, hardworking and proud of their culture and martial arts. They are fun-loving and have music in their blood. Yet today, the northeast is generally lagging behind the rest of the country as far as development is concerned.

I reminisced of the many crossings of the 'pagla' (mad) Digaru river on elephant back to reach Tezu, the district HQ, in the early 1980s; the freak accident when the jeep overturned and we nearly fell hundreds of feet into the Lohit river; trekking over a thousand kilometers; and my battalion's participation in operations on the Indo-Myanmar border. We were accorded a warm reception, with a ceremonial guard of honour, at the Raj Bhawan helipad at Itanagar, where Chief Minister Dorjee Khandu and his entire cabinet and the who's who of the state had gathered to welcome us.

Arunachal Pradesh, earlier known as NEFA (North-East Frontier Agency) has always been considered a geo-strategically important part of our country, with a common boundary with Bhutan, China and Myanmar. Therefore, successive leaderships at the centre have always given it a very special and unique status while formulating the development priorities for the country. It is well known that our first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, had tremendous love and respect for the tribes of Arunachal and their culture and traditions. He had a firm belief in the policy of letting the people here develop at a pace and in a way that was determined by them rather than imposing any development model on them (Nehru-Elwin Policy). Much before the Indo–China war of 1962, he had visited this frontier state in the 1950s. The strong bonds continued during the tenures of Indira Gandhi, who accorded Arunachal the status of a Union Territory, and Rajiv Gandhi, who bestowed on it full statehood in 1987. The people of the state have, in turn, reposed their faith in the policies of the central government. In fact, the famous incident of one of the 'gaon-burhas' (a title for a respected villager elder) of Apatani plateau proposing to marry Indira and